

software creates and manages data, it can natively read into those files. It also means that you get to see the PSD as a derivative of the Nepal vacation, even though it's called "Untitled-1.psd".

Another great feature is that because all data has relationships, you can theoretically forget about having to synchronise or update information. Another scenario: you have contacts in your e-mail address book. Suresh has changed his mobile number and office address, and sends you an e-mail to inform you. You make the change in your Outlook contacts. Unfortunately, you also have a third-party software that prints labels for your newsletters. You have an Excel file that contains mobile numbers of your friends, a mobile phone manager software that also stores these numbers, a computer on the network where billing addresses are stored, etc. Now you're going to have to go about finding everything with Suresh in it and update it... not! WinFS, if set to do so, will have already updated the changes everywhere, thanks to its relationship building and database storage.

There's so much more to WinFS, we cannot cover it all in this space. It's the perfect example of how the OS might be revolutionised by just adding a different method of dealing with data. Our Sixth Sense is in overdrive when we consider the possibilities, and brings us to the conclusion that WinFS, or other, similar filesystems, are our way into the future.

There once was a popular rumour circulating that Google was working on GoogleOS. This would be an OS that ran from the Net and

offered you all the functionality you needed online. Some still insist that Google is ultimately working towards this, and is still developing GoogleOS. Knowing Google, this is quite possible—they've surprised us so much in the past with innovations, we now believe anything is possible. But is the idea of an Internet OS really far-fetched?

What's to stop someone from making a Web-based OS? The Net is nothing more than a rather humungous LAN. Using a Live CD, USB drive, or even network booting, those with broadband connections could conceivably boot off the Net. Of course, broadband connections need to be omnipresent, and there has to be some way of making sure people can still use their computers when their ISP goes down. But these are not really unsolvable problems. Look out for something like a GoogleOS—it may be closer than you think.

As mobile devices go, we've already seen Apple integrate OS X into the iPhone—a lighter version, no doubt. Windows CE also brings the familiarity of the Microsoft OS to mobile devices, and enables you to do things you normally cannot on regular mobiles. As the hardware gets more powerful, we see mobile software keeping pace. In five years you might perhaps be able to load Windows XP on your mobile phone. Still speculation, but not completely improbable.

With OSes, we expect a lot to change, and radically. If the computer is ever going to be more powerful than it already is, it needs a makeover, it needs smarter software. ☐

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Software That Thinks

The future is basic AI, hopefully more...

Software is what we spend most of our lives using, whether it's an office suite, an instant messenger, a browser, an image editor. Although we've seen some brilliant interfaces and UIs, software isn't as smart as we want it to be. It's still a very unidirectional flow of information—you telling the software what you want.

Manufacturers have started making more intuitive software, and laying things out better

so everything is within easy reach—Office 2007 is an example. However, while writing this piece in Office 2007, when this writer wants to highlight each header, he has to do so manually. Wouldn't it be nice if our software could think, see the writer highlight one header, then the second, and then at least ask if the writer wanted all the headers highlighted? This applies for repetitive tasks in any software.



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